

Passage One

Questions 46 to 50 are based on the following passage.

Imagine you're an alien sent to Earth to document the behaviour of the mammals inhabiting the planet. You stumble into a movie theatre that's showing the latest Hollywood horror film.

Several dozen humans are gathered together in a dark, undecorated room. They're all staring at a rectangular area on which patterns of light change rapidly.

They are clearly in a state of high arousal. Their heart rate is elevated, they occasionally glance around nervously, and they sometimes jump collectively in their seats, and emit high-pitched warning calls.

Eventually, the lights come up and the rectangular screen goes black. The humans stand up and leave the room, chatting and laughing, and showing signs of pleasure.

Why do these humans voluntarily expose themselves to what appears to be a deeply unpleasant experience? And why do they react so strongly to those patterns of light on a screen?

I am fascinated with the paradox of horror—the strange fact that many people seek out scary entertainment.

I think the answer to the puzzle lies in human nature.

My research suggests that we humans evolved to find pleasure in situations that allow us to experience negative emotions in a safe context. You can see these elements of horror in children's games. Take hide-and-seek for example, which is a simulation of a predator-prey interaction. The kid hides and the adult pretends to be a predator, searching for the child while howling like a dangerous beast.

that kind of activity deeply satisfying, presumably because it gives one a safe experience of a potentially catastrophic scenario.

They find it pleasurable, and pleasure is evolution's way of motivating us toward adaptive behaviour.

Horror is pleasurable to many people because it lets us play with negative emotions and develop coping strategies. We learn what it feels like to be truly afraid, and we learn how to handle negative emotion.

How, then, does horror work? My research suggests that horror works by exploiting an ancient set of biological defence mechanisms—an evolved fear system, which we share with other animals. But humans are uniquely imaginative, and we use our evolved imagination to travel into virtual worlds that are full of danger.

There are good reasons for watching a horror film, even if you're not a loyal horror fan. If you make it through the film in one piece, you'll probably experience a strong sense of mastery, a sense that you were able to make it through an appalling experience. Anyway, watching a horror film makes you better at handling your own fear, and who knows when that will become critically relevant?

The alien finds the audience in the movie theatre clearly in a state of _____.

- A) total mindfulness
- B) extreme excitement
- C) spiritual elevation
- D) intense curiosity

Why do many people seek out scary entertainment, according to the author's research?

- A) They gain experience in overcoming horror in real life.
- B) They find joy in going through simulated horrible experiences.
- C) They have learned from hide-and-seek as kids the thrill involved.
- D) They have evolved to gain pleasure in escaping life-threatening situations.

What do children learn from hide-and-seek?

- A) How to avoid falling prey to an attacker.
- B) How to simulate a predator-prey interaction.
- C) How to keep themselves from catastrophic errors.
- D) How to turn a dangerous scenario into a safe one.

Why is horror gratifying to many people?

- A) It reminds them of an ancient set of biological defence mechanisms.
- B) It triggers their imagination to travel into dangerous virtual worlds.
- C) It allows them to learn what fear feels like and how to tackle it.
- D) It activates their evolved fear system and their unique fantasy.

What will one experience if they watch a horror film through without being hurt?

- A) A strong sense of clear relevance.
- B) A profound sense of good fortune.
- C) A profound sense of intense relief.
- D) A strong sense of being in control.

Passage Two

Questions 51 to 55 are based on the following passage.

An awakening has been taking place in the physical world against the beauty model that has been dictated for years. But in the digital arena, social media determines what is considered beautiful.

The two opposing struggles are taking place in parallel. In the physical world, the struggle goes against the underlying pressure exerted on women to conform to an unrealistic beauty ideal. As part of the struggle, various media outlets have presented women whose bodies don't correspond to the so-called ideal. All those women who previously been excluded from the covers of magazines, television series and the public agenda, have become "legitimate". At the same time, a group of influencers have begun to upload to social media photos of themselves without makeup, and even photos in which they highlight supposed flaws.

Technology has reshaped our beauty ideal and is doing a great job communicating that message to the masses. One of the bizarre legacies of the past decade is the popularity of the "cyborg look", which illustrates what Americans will look like in 2050.

The cyborg look spread rapidly. Today, however, the Instagram face has become the new beauty ideal.

The internalization of accepted beauty norms is much more effective when there is active involvement in

ered by the social media platforms—the ability to like, write a comment, compare, share.

Once the desired beauty ideal has been internalized, users are given tools or features to change their appearance to suit the accepted beauty ideal such as editing the image, choosing the ideal filter, the right background.

A survey conducted in the United States revealed that more than 50% filter the images before posting them. And you will not be surprised to hear that the majority of them are women. One of the significant consequences of obsessive filtering is the emerging tendency to treat oneself as an object to be observed and judged, in the same way another person observes and judges from the side.

The effect of the filters is already far beyond amiable amusement. The filters and the entire game played on the networks affect the mental health of the users. According to a study, apps like Instagram, Snapchat and MeTune allow users to achieve a level of perfection that was previously only observed in beauty magazines.

Even though humanity has always cherished beauty, in the last decade our obsession with looks has reached an unprecedented peak. The time spent on social media creates an urge to achieve an impossible beauty ideal so powerful that the only thing that can fix it is not cosmetic intervention, but mental health care.

What do we learn about beauty in the digital arena?

A) It dictates the taste of digital media.

C) It has ushered in a new awakening.